



THE REAL
DEPRESSION T_T

CHAPTER 4

THE BUG

The strange message remained on the screen.

Arjun stared at it.

I stared at Arjun.

The police officer stared at both of us.

Nobody spoke.

Finally, Arjun sighed.

“Okay.”

He pulled the keyboard closer.

“I think I found it.”

I stepped forward.

“You found the problem?”

Arjun nodded.

“Yes.”

The entire crowd became interested again.

Someone shouted from a car:

“IS THE ROAD GOING TO OPEN?”

Arjun ignored him.

He pointed at the screen.

“This program is supposed to send information from one part of the computer to another.”

I nodded slowly.

I wasn’t a programmer, but even I could understand that.

“Think of it like delivering a letter,” Arjun continued. “One part of the computer writes the letter, and another part is supposed to receive it.”

“Okay.”

“The problem is that the letter is being sent to the wrong address.”

I looked at the screen.

“So... the computer is sending something to the wrong place?”

“Exactly.”

He clicked through several files.

“And because it keeps looking for the information in the wrong place, everything starts breaking.”

The police officer nodded.

“So the computer isn't broken?”

“No.”

“Then what's broken?”

Arjun pointed at the code.

“My instructions.”

I finally understood.

The computer was doing exactly what it had been told to do.

The problem was that Arjun had told it to do the wrong thing.

He had spent hours searching for some mysterious, complicated problem.

But the real problem was painfully simple.

One small mistake.

One wrong reference.

One tiny instruction pointing in the wrong direction.

Arjun stared at the screen.

Then he whispered:

“Eight hours.”

I looked at him.

“You spent eight hours on that?”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

He didn't answer.

He simply fixed the line.

Click.

The screen changed.

SYSTEM NORMAL.

The UPS stopped complaining.

The CRT stabilized.

The RGB lights returned to their completely unnecessary glory.

Arjun leaned back in his chair.

“Done.”

Nobody moved.

Then the police officer looked toward the traffic.

“Alright!”

He raised his arm.

“LET THEM THROUGH!”

The cars began moving.

One by one.

Then faster.

Cars rolled past the platform.

Buses moved.

Trucks moved.

The giant traffic jam finally began disappearing.

Drivers shouted things as they passed.

“GOOD LUCK, BRO!”

“FIX YOUR LIFE NEXT!”

“TURN OFF THE RGB!”

Arjun ignored them.

Within minutes, the road was almost empty.

I looked at my car.

Then at Arjun.

I should have left.

My grandmother was still waiting at home.

But something kept bothering me.

Arjun had just spent eight hours fighting a problem that could have been explained in one sentence.

And I knew something about computers.

Not enough to call myself an expert.

But enough to understand how frustrating programming could be.

I walked toward him.

“Can I help?”

Arjun immediately looked at me.

“No.”

I blinked.

“What?”

“It's private.”

“I just want to help.”

“No.”

“Why?”

“Because it's private.”

I looked at the computer.

Then at him.

"I'm a web developer."

Arjun paused.

"You are?"

"Yeah."

"Employed?"

I hesitated.

"...Not currently."

Arjun looked back at the computer.

"So you're unemployed."

"Yes."

"Then you have time."

I wasn't sure whether that was an insult or an invitation.

Probably both.

I pulled up a chair.

Arjun immediately moved his keyboard away from me.

"Don't touch anything."

"I wasn't going to."

"Don't look at the code."

"Fine."

"Don't ask what the program does."

"Fine."

"Don't ask what language it is."

I sighed.

"Fine."

He stared at me suspiciously.

Then turned back to the monitor.

I waited.

A few seconds passed.

“So—”

“PRIVATE.”

“I didn't even finish.”

“Still private.”

I laughed.

“Okay, Arjun.”

He continued typing.

I watched the screen from a distance.

Then I noticed something.

The code wasn't as complicated as I had expected.

It was messy.

Very messy.

There were comments everywhere.

Random notes.

Old experiments.

Half-finished functions.

And what appeared to be several completely unnecessary pieces of code.

I pointed at the screen.

“That part looks unnecessary.”

Arjun immediately covered the monitor.

“PRIVATE.”

“I was just saying—”

“PRIVATE.”

“I could probably simplify—”

“KEEP IT SIMPLE.”

I stopped.

He looked at me seriously.

“If you're going to help, explain things so a person who has never written code can understand them.”

I nodded.

That was actually fair.

So I tried again.

“Okay. The computer is basically following a list of instructions.”

Arjun nodded.

“One instruction was pointing to the wrong place.”

“Yes.”

“And because it was pointing to the wrong place, the rest of the program couldn't find what it needed.”

“Yes.”

“And that caused the error.”

“Yes.”

I smiled.

“See? That wasn't so difficult.”

Arjun stared at me.

Then said:

“It's still private.”

I laughed again.

For the first time that night, Arjun smiled.

Just slightly.

The road was finally empty.

The rain was slowing down.

The police officer was leaving.

The cars were gone.

And the mysterious computer was working again.

I looked at Arjun's ridiculous setup.

The old CRT.

The wooden platform.

The glowing RGB lights.

The cables.

The UPS.

Everything looked completely absurd.

But somehow...

it worked.

I picked up my car keys.

"I really need to get home."

Arjun nodded.

"Yeah."

I started walking away.

Then I stopped.

"Arjun?"

He looked up.

"Why are you doing all this here?"

He looked at the computer.

Then at the empty road.

Then back at me.

For a moment, he said nothing.

Finally, he answered:

“That's private.”

I sighed.

Of course.

PRIVATE.

404: HOME NOT FOUND

At exactly midnight, one ordinary driver gets trapped in an impossible traffic jam.

The cause?

A programmer.

A computer.

A wooden platform.

A suspicious transformer.

And an unnecessary amount of RGB.

While everyone else wants to go home, Arjun has only one mission:

FIX THE BUG.

But there's one problem.

He won't let anyone see his code.

Because...

IT'S PRIVATE.

A completely unnecessary story about coding, traffic, and one extremely stubborn programmer.

Warning: May cause readers to say “bro” approximately 47 times per chapter.



MONEY FOLLOWS MY BROTHER!! MONEY FOLLOWS

MRP : RS. 50

DESI DAARU PET ME UTARU!!